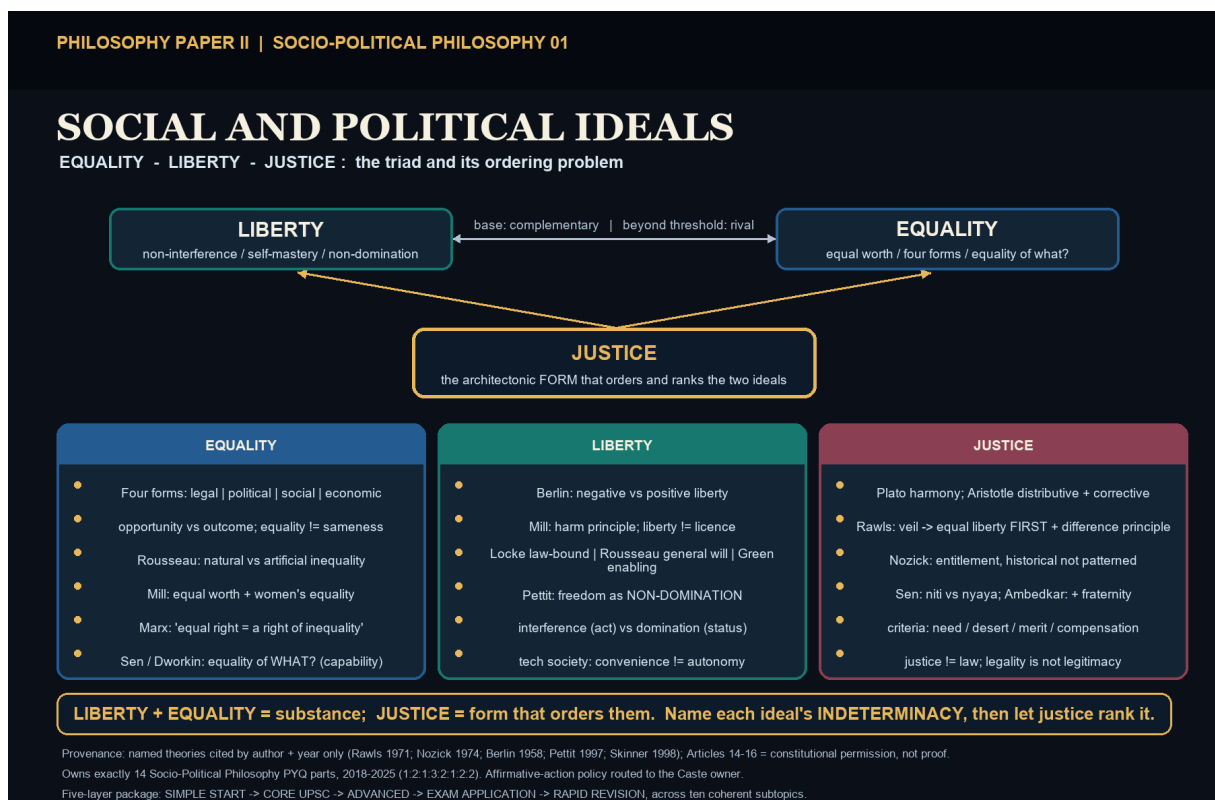


SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

SOCIAL AND POLITICAL IDEALS - Layered Solved-Practice Workbook - Philosophy Paper II Socio-Political Philosophy 01

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing



Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

SOCIAL AND POLITICAL IDEALS - Layered Solved-Practice Workbook - Philosophy Paper II Socio-Political Philosophy 01

Workbook Source Audit

- Exact PYQ wording, year and marks: local Socio-Political Philosophy Paper II bank, 2018-2025.
- Exactly 14 owner questions (2018:1, 2019:2, 2020:1, 2021:3, 2022:2, 2023:1, 2024:2, 2025:2).
- Ownership discipline: democracy-form questions (Forms of Government) and Marxism-as-ideology questions (Political Ideologies) are kept separate; the 2022 Q2(c) equity/equality part is routed to this owner (equity vs equality, Marx as frame). The affirmative-action policy debate is routed to the Caste (Gandhi-Ambedkar) owner.
- Model solutions authored at examiner grade: thesis -> named source / argument -> analysis -> objection/reply -> graded verdict, each closing with a "Why this earns marks" note.
- MCQs: 40 core plus 8 remedial, exactly 48, strict A-B-C-D rotation twelve times.
- Original Mains: one solved 10-marker, one solved 15-marker and one solved 20-marker.
- Provenance discipline observed throughout (Rawls 1971; Nozick 1974; Berlin 1958; Mill 1859/1869; Pettit 1997; Skinner 1998); named-scholar syntheses (non-domination module, distributive-criteria grid) carry no page/edition/quotation; Articles 14-16 are a constitutional permission, not a philosophical justification.
- No current-affairs anchor is used (no verified 2026 development forced); relevance is static and syllabus-driven.
- Final consolidated register notes are intentionally excluded from this workbook.

Practice Design

The workbook sequence is the fourteen exact verified PYQs -> 40 core MCQs -> 8 remedial MCQs -> original 10/15/20-mark Mains practice. There are no register notes and no canonical apparatus block in this workbook.

DIRECTIVE -> THESIS -> DOCTRINE -> NAMED SOURCE / EXAMPLE -> OBJECTION / REPLY -> VERDICT

SOLVED PYQ BANK - EXACTLY 14 VERIFIED OWNER QUESTIONS

Exact wording, year and marks are parsed from the local Socio-Political Philosophy Paper II bank for 2018-2025. This clause owns exactly 14 primary parts (2018:1, 2019:2, 2020:1, 2021:3, 2022:2, 2023:1, 2024:2, 2025:2). Ownership discipline: democracy-form questions owned by Forms of Government and Marxism-as-ideology questions owned by Political Ideologies are NOT counted here; the 2022 Q2(c) equity/equality part is routed to this owner because the demanded concept is equity vs equality (Marx supplies only the frame).

Solved PYQ 1 - 2018 Q2(a), 20 marks

Question: How far can liberty and equality be considered as distinctive features of democracy ? Discuss.

Model solution

Thesis. Liberty and equality are **DISTINCTIVE** but not **EXHAUSTIVE** features of democracy: they constitute its normative core, yet each is indeterminate until justice and fraternity fix which liberties are basic and which equalities matter. "How far" therefore demands a degree-judgment, not a yes/no.

- **Liberty as a democratic feature.** Democracy institutionalises negative liberties (speech, association, dissent) and a positive, self-ruling liberty -- Rousseau's citizen obeys a law he helps author. Without protected liberty, elections are hollow.

- **Equality as a democratic feature.** Political equality (equal vote, equal eligibility for office) and social equality (absence of status hierarchy) give democracy its non-oligarchic standing. One-person-one-vote is itself an equality of civic worth.

- **Their relation (the mark-bearing move).** At the level of basic liberties the

two REINFORCE (free speech for all is a liberty AND an equality); they conflict only beyond a threshold, where market liberty breeds inequality or aggressive equalising curbs choice. Rawls's lexical priority of equal basic liberties shows liberty need not be traded for aggregate welfare.

- **Qualification / limit.** Liberty and equality alone do not prevent majority tyranny, propaganda or the hollowing of political equality by social hierarchy. Ambedkar's warning is decisive: political democracy is unstable without SOCIAL democracy rooted in liberty, equality AND fraternity; justice supplies the ordering criterion.

Verdict. Liberty and equality are genuinely distinctive of democracy, but only as far as justice orders them and fraternity sustains them; beyond the threshold they need adjudication, so they are necessary features, not sufficient ones.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it treats "how far" as a degree question, shows the base-level complementarity AND the marginal conflict, and closes with the justice/fraternity supplement rather than one-sided praise.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2019 Q1(a), 10 marks

Question: How far do you think John Rawls is continuing with Plato's concept of justice?

Model solution

Thesis. Rawls continues Plato only in a broad architectonic sense -- justice as the virtue that structures a well-ordered whole -- and breaks with him radically on method, citizenship and equality. State the criterion of "continuity" first.

- **Continuity.** For Plato, justice is right-order: each part of soul and city performs its own function in harmony. For Rawls, justice is the first virtue of the basic structure -- fair terms of cooperation among free and equal persons. Both make justice the ORDERING virtue of the social whole, not one desire among others.

- **Break 1 -- method.** Plato reaches justice through the metaphysics of the Forms and functional differentiation; Rawls through a hypothetical device, the original position under a veil of ignorance -- a device of representation, not a cosmology.

- **Break 2 -- equality and citizenship.** Plato's order is a fixed hierarchy of natural kinds; Rawls builds in equal basic liberties and fair equality of opportunity for equal citizens, explicitly rejecting caste-like closure.

Verdict. The continuity is thin (justice as the structure of a good society); the discontinuity is deep (democratic-egalitarian method against fixed hierarchy). Rawls inherits Plato's QUESTION, not his ANSWER.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it names the axis of continuity before judging, and separates a shared question from opposed answers instead of forcing a single verdict.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2019 Q4(b), 15 marks

Question: Does liberty put limitations to equality? Discuss.

Model solution

Thesis. Liberty limits equality only at the margin; at the level of basic liberties and equal civic standing the two reinforce each other. This is a "how far" stem, so the mark-bearing move is a conditional verdict.

- **Where liberty limits equality.** Unrestricted freedom of contract, property accumulation and market power let the strong dominate the weak, generating material inequality (Rousseau: convention converts difference into domination). Heavy protection of the private domain can block redistribution.

- **Where it does not.** Equal basic liberties ARE a form of equality; securing them for all is simultaneously a liberty and an equal civic standing. Rawls's priority rules permit inequality only under fair opportunity and benefit to the least advantaged, so liberty is not licence to entrench privilege.

- **The reframing (depth).** On the republican view, material dependence is

itself DOMINATION; certain equalising measures therefore INCREASE freedom rather than trading against it -- the un-interfered-with dependent is still unfree. So "liberty vs equality" is not a zero-sum law.

Verdict. Liberty limits equality where market advantage expands unchecked, and supports it where basic liberties and non-domination are secured; the honest answer is a matter of degree, decided by justice.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it gives a genuine degree-judgment, deploys non-domination to dissolve the trade-off, and avoids a flat yes/no.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2020 Q1(a), 10 marks

Question: Is the concept of liberty realizable in the modern technological society? Explain.

Model solution

Thesis. Liberty is realisable in a technological society, but only under active vigilance against surveillance, manipulation and the concentration of informational power -- convenience is not autonomy.

- **The enabling case.** Technology expands knowledge, mobility, communication and choice; it can widen the effective capacity to act (a Green-style, enabling freedom).

- **The threat.** Modern coercion is infrastructural and informational, not only legal: algorithmic nudging can leave formal options open while shaping choices invisibly, and data concentration creates a standing capacity for arbitrary interference -- domination even without overt interference.

- **The condition of realisability.** Liberty survives if the system is transparent, accountable and contestable, preserving zones of non-domination; where it is opaque and unaccountable, formal freedom masks dependence.

Verdict. Liberty is realisable, but conditionally -- it is secured by transparency, accountability and non-domination, and endangered wherever convenience is mistaken for autonomy.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it answers the yes/no with a condition, distinguishes convenience from autonomy, and names the informational form of modern unfreedom.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2021 Q1(a), 10 marks

Question: Discuss critically the distributive theory of justice as propounded by R. Nozick.

Model solution

Thesis. Nozick's is a HISTORICAL (entitlement) theory, not a distributive one in the patterned sense: a distribution is just if it arose through just steps, whatever its final shape. Powerful as a warning, it is incomplete on its own premises.

- **Doctrine.** Justice in holdings has three principles -- justice in ACQUISITION (how unowned things are first justly held), justice in TRANSFER (voluntary exchange and gift) and justice in RECTIFICATION (correcting past injustice). There is no required end-state pattern.

- **Historical vs patterned.** Patterned principles (equality, need, merit) judge the shape of the distribution; historical principles judge the PROCESS. The Wilt Chamberlain argument shows that if people freely pay to watch him, the resulting inequality is just, and maintaining any fixed pattern would require continuous interference with voluntary transfers.

- **Critique.** The acquisition and rectification principles are the weakest links: both need an independent criterion, and real starting distributions are tainted by conquest, coercion and background injustice, so "voluntariness" is rarely clean.

Verdict. Nozick's side-constraint, self-ownership warning against overreaching redistribution is a permanent contribution; but because his own foundational principles are under-specified, entitlement theory cannot bypass the problem of unjust starting points.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it fixes the historical/patterned distinction, uses Wilt Chamberlain as argument (not decoration), and lands the critique on acquisition/rectification.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2021 Q1(b), 10 marks

Question: How does Rousseau distinguish between natural and artificial inequality ? Explain.

Model solution

Thesis. Rousseau distinguishes NATURAL (physical) inequality from MORAL or POLITICAL (artificial) inequality, and his point is diagnostic: the most oppressive inequalities are socially produced, not natural.

- **The distinction.** Natural inequality covers differences of age, strength, health and intelligence. Moral/political (artificial) inequality covers wealth, honour, power, dependence and social superiority -- established by convention.

- **The argument.** Natural differences become politically toxic only when institutions convert them into durable domination and vanity. Civil society -- above all property and the passion for comparison -- deepens dependence and manufactures hierarchy.

- **The nuance.** Rousseau does not say ALL inequality is conventional; he says the oppressive forms are socially created and maintained. The claim is diagnostic, not pastoral -- he is not romanticising nature.

Verdict. One person being stronger is natural; one person commanding another because convention sanctifies property and status is moral/political inequality -- and that, for Rousseau, is where injustice lives.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it states both terms precisely, explains the convert-difference-into-domination mechanism, and blocks the "romantic Rousseau" misreading.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2021 Q2(a), 20 marks

Question: Discuss whether Amartya Sen's idea of justice is an improvement upon Rawls's theory of justice.

Model solution

Thesis. Whether Sen improves on Rawls is CRITERION-RELATIVE: judged by attention to realised freedom and remediable injustice Sen improves on Rawls; judged by the need for determinate institutional principles Rawls retains the advantage. Name the test before applying it.

- **Rawls in brief.** A just basic structure chosen behind the veil of ignorance: equal basic liberties, fair equality of opportunity and the difference principle. Its focus is ideal, transcendental and institution-centred.

- **Sen's reorientation.** Sen contrasts NITI (correctness of rules and institutions) with NYAYA (justice realised in actual lives). A society may have fine rules yet produce grave injustice, so we should COMPARE feasible social states and remove manifest injustice rather than seek one perfectly just structure; the metric is CAPABILITIES, refined through PUBLIC REASONING.

- **The improvement, assessed.** By the criterion of realised freedom, Sen improves on Rawls -- primary goods ignore the diversity of conversion into real freedom, and transcendental design can neglect how people actually fare. But by the criterion of institutional determinacy, comparative ranking without an ideal benchmark can under-determine choice among rival improvements.

- **Rawlsian reply.** Institutions remain indispensable preconditions of justice; comparison still presupposes standards the ideal theory helps supply.

Verdict. Sen improves on Rawls in ORIENTATION (from arrangements to lives, from resources to capabilities), but does not simply supersede him; "improvement" holds only on a stated criterion, and both are needed.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it states the criterion of improvement first, uses niti/nyaya and capabilities as argument, concedes what Rawls still does better, and gives a criterion-relative verdict.

Solved PYQ 8 - 2022 Q1(d), 10 marks

Question: "Complete liberty may lead to inequality while order and restrictions imply a necessary loss of freedom." Critically discuss.

Model solution

Thesis. The statement states a real tension but overstates it: "complete liberty" does tend to inequality, yet order and restriction are not NECESSARILY a loss of freedom. Critically, the word "necessary" is where the claim fails.

- **First half -- true.** Unrestricted liberty (freedom of contract, unchecked property and market power) lets the strong dominate the weak; Rousseau shows how convention converts advantage into durable domination. So complete liberty can indeed generate inequality.

- **Second half -- only partly true.** On the negative view every law subtracts from liberty. But on the republican view NON-ARBITRARY law is FREEDOM-CONSTITUTING: it strips private persons of arbitrary power, so a contestable law that tracks citizens' interests can restrict WITHOUT reducing real freedom. Order can enable liberty rather than merely cost it.

- **Adjudication.** Both halves hold only BEYOND a threshold; at the level of basic liberties, order and freedom coincide. The dilemma treats a marginal trade-off as a law of all cases.

Verdict. Complete liberty risks inequality, and SOME restrictions do cost freedom -- but the claim that restriction NECESSARILY reduces freedom is false; just, contestable order can constitute liberty.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it attacks the modal word "necessary", uses the freedom-constituting-law point, and delivers a graded rather than either/or verdict.

Solved PYQ 9 - 2022 Q2(c), 15 marks

Question: Explain the difference between the notion of equity and equality with reference to Marxian philosophy.

Model solution

Thesis. In Marxian philosophy, EQUALITY is the application of one common measure to all, while EQUITY is differentiated distribution responsive to real need; Marx's deeper claim is that formal equal right can be a right of INEQUALITY.

- **The distinction.** Equality = same standard for everyone (equivalent exchange among legal equals). Equity = shares differentiated by need and actual condition ("to each according to his need"). Equal treatment of unequally-placed people reproduces disadvantage.

- **Marx's argument.** Bourgeois equality abstracts from class structure. The wage contract LOOKS free and equal, but a right measured by a common standard is applied to people who differ in need, burden and family condition -- so equal right is, in content, a right of inequality; and the wage relation itself is structurally exploitative.

- **The two-stage caution.** The need-principle belongs to a HIGHER stage of cooperation where alienated labour and scarcity are transformed; it is not a market-time salary rule, and reading it as one invites the "vague / weakens incentive" objection.

Verdict. Equality and equity diverge because a single measure cannot be fair to unequal needs; Marx uses the distinction to expose the class content hidden beneath formally equal exchange.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it fixes the measure-vs-need distinction, roots it in the equal-right-as-right-of-inequality argument, and flags the higher-stage qualification without drifting into a Political-Ideologies essay.

Solved PYQ 10 - 2023 Q1(a), 10 marks

Question: What is meant by justice as fairness? Explain Rawls' theory of justice.

Model solution

Thesis. "Justice as fairness" means that the principles of justice are those that free and equal persons would choose under fair conditions; Rawls builds those conditions into the original position and derives two lexically ordered principles.

- **The device.** In the ORIGINAL POSITION, parties choose principles for the basic structure behind a VEIL OF IGNORANCE -- not knowing their class, sex, talents, religion or conception of the good. Ignorance of arbitrary advantage makes the choice fair; it is a device of representation, not a historical contract.

- **The two principles.** (1) Each has an equal claim to a fully adequate scheme of equal BASIC LIBERTIES. (2) Social and economic inequalities must satisfy (a) FAIR equality of opportunity and (b) the DIFFERENCE PRINCIPLE -- they may stand only if they benefit the LEAST ADVANTAGED.

- **Priority and justification.** Liberty is LEXICALLY prior (never traded for economic gain); fair opportunity precedes the difference principle. Justification proceeds by REFLECTIVE EQUILIBRIUM -- mutual adjustment of principles and considered judgments.

Verdict. Justice as fairness is a deontological liberal egalitarianism: liberty is basic, and inequality is tolerated only under fair opportunity and benefit to the least advantaged.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it defines fairness through the fair choice situation, states the principles with their PRIORITY, and adds reflective equilibrium rather than listing slogans.

Solved PYQ 11 - 2024 Q1(a), 10 marks

Question: Briefly discuss Plato's concept of justice.

Model solution

Thesis. For Plato, justice is not external distribution but ORDER and HARMONY: each part of the soul and each class of the city performing its own proper function without usurping another's.

- **Soul and city.** In the city, rulers rule, auxiliaries defend and producers provide; in the soul, reason governs spirit and appetite. Justice is the virtue that coordinates plurality into a harmonious whole.

- **What it is not.** Justice is not merely paying debts or obeying law; it is an inner and civic right-order grounded in functional differentiation and the rule of reason.

- **Criticism and reply.** Objection: Plato subordinates individuality to a fixed hierarchy. Reply: his aim is a norm of COMPETENCE and organic harmony, not arbitrary privilege -- though the closure of classes remains a real cost.

Verdict. Plato's justice is a powerful ideal of harmony and appropriate function; its enduring value is the insight that justice orders the whole, even if its fixed hierarchy is rejected by modern egalitarian citizenship.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it gives the soul-city parallel, distinguishes harmony from distribution, and balances the standard criticism with its reply.

Solved PYQ 12 - 2024 Q2(b), 15 marks

Question: Critically evaluate the concepts of liberty and equality as political ideals.

Model solution

Thesis. Liberty and equality are the twin political ideals of a free society, but each is powerful only when specified and disciplined; evaluated critically, they are complementary at the base and rivalrous at the margin, and both need justice.

- **Liberty, specified.** Negative liberty (freedom from interference) guards against coercion and paternalism; positive liberty (self-mastery) and the republican third family (non-domination) capture what mere non-interference misses. Objection: negative liberty can serve the already powerful -- true if isolated from fair background conditions.

- **Equality, specified.** Formal, political, social and economic equality, plus the modern question "equality of what?" (welfare, resources, capabilities). Objection: aggressive equalising can flatten choice and desert -- true only if it ignores thresholds, fair opportunity and capability floors.

- **Critical relation.** Equal basic liberties ARE an equality; conflict appears only beyond a threshold. Non-domination shows some equalisation INCREASES freedom (material dependence is domination). Rawls's priority rules keep liberty from being traded away while permitting justified inequality.

Verdict. As political ideals, liberty and equality are indispensable but INDETERMINATE alone -- each is silent about which liberties and which equalities matter; justice supplies the ordering criterion, so they are best defended together.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it specifies both ideals (three liberties, four equalities + the metric question), runs objection-reply on each, and closes with the ordering role of justice.

Solved PYQ 13 - 2025 Q1(e), 10 marks

Question: Discuss the salient features of equality according to J.S. Mill.

Model solution

Thesis. Mill is a QUALIFIED liberal egalitarian: he affirms equal moral and civic standing -- above all women's equality -- while resisting a crude levelling that would suppress individuality.

- **Salient features.** (1) Equal moral worth -- each person counts, none discounted by birth. (2) Equality before law and citizenship -- privilege by status is indefensible. (3) WOMEN'S equality -- in The Subjection of Women the legal and social subordination of women is a relic of domination, not nature. (4) Equality compatible with INDIVIDUALITY -- sameness is not the goal, free self-development is. (5) Hostility to custom-made hierarchy. (6) A qualified economic concern -- open to reforming property and labour relations, not to coercive levelling.

- **The core argument.** A society that excludes half its members or attaches rights to status wastes human capacities and violates utility properly understood; the "nature" invoked to justify subordination is itself socially manufactured through subjection.

- **Limit.** Mill remains too individualist to reach structural economic inequality -- but within liberalism he radicalises equality by extending it from formal rights to social relations, especially gender.

Verdict. Mill's equality is equality of STATUS, RIGHTS and CHANCE compatible with liberty and individuality -- egalitarian in worth and gender, restrained in economics.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it lists Mill's features precisely, foregrounds the feminist argument and the individuality proviso, and states the structural limit rather than over-claiming.

Solved PYQ 14 - 2025 Q4(a), 20 marks

Question: How are both equality and liberty inadequate as social and political ideals without justice? Discuss.

Model solution

Thesis. Equality and liberty are indispensable but INADEQUATE by themselves, because each is indeterminate about its own content; justice is the architectonic ideal that supplies the ordering criteria and decides their scope and priority.

- **Why liberty alone is inadequate.** "Liberty" does not tell us WHICH liberties are basic, or how to weigh one person's freedom against another's. A tyrant and a citizen both invoke freedom; negative, positive and republican conceptions pull apart. Only a theory of justice ranks basic liberties and protects them (Rawls's lexical priority).

- **Why equality alone is inadequate.** "Equality" is under-specified -- of status, rights, opportunity, welfare, resources, capability or outcome? Each metric yields different institutions, and without a criterion, equality collapses into either mechanical levelling or empty formalism.

- **What justice supplies.** Justice provides the adjudicatory criteria -- desert, fairness, entitlement, need, capability, rectification and public reason -- that say which inequalities are justified and which liberties are basic. Compare the positions: liberty-first (Nozick) protects self-ownership but lets background injustice hollow real freedom; equality-first levelling flags oppression but flattens choice and desert; justice-as-ordering balances them by principle.

- **Indian anchor.** Ambedkar: political democracy (equal votes, formal liberty) is unstable without SOCIAL democracy -- liberty, equality AND fraternity -- so justice must reach lived social standing, not only procedure.

Verdict. Liberty and equality are the substance of a just society, but justice is its FORM: it is the ideal that disciplines and coordinates the other two, and without it each remains normatively incomplete.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it proves inadequacy by showing each ideal is indeterminate about its own content, compares three ordering positions, anchors in Ambedkar, and ends with the architectonic verdict.

ORIGINAL MCQ MASTERY SET - EXACTLY 48 QUESTIONS

Questions 1-40 are core coverage - four per subtopic across the ten subtopics; Questions 41-48 are remedial items targeting the most common misreadings. Correct answers rotate strictly A -> B -> C -> D 12 times.

MCQ 1

The thesis that liberty and equality are 'indeterminate until justice orders them' means that:

A. each ideal is silent about which of its own variants (which liberties, which equality) should prevail
B. liberty and equality are meaningless concepts
C. justice is the only genuine political value
D. equality must always defeat liberty

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Liberty does not by itself say which liberties are basic, and equality does not say which equality (of status, resource, welfare or capability) matters; justice supplies the ordering criteria.

MCQ 2

Justice is called the 'architectonic' ideal of the triad because it:

A. is chronologically the oldest of the three ideals B. supplies the ordering criteria that rank and reconcile liberty and equality C. abolishes the need for liberty and equality D. is guaranteed only by written constitutions

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Architectonic = ordering: justice provides the criteria (desert, fairness, need, entitlement, capability) that decide the scope and priority of the other two ideals.

MCQ 3

'Directive-sensitivity' in answering these questions means:

A. always agreeing with the statement quoted in the question B. writing the longest possible answer C. tailoring the answer's structure to the command word (discuss / critically evaluate / how far) D. citing as many thinkers as possible regardless of relevance

Correct answer: C

Explanation: The directive fixes the required structure: 'discuss' exposes a tension, 'critically evaluate' demands objection-reply, 'how far' demands a degree judgment.

MCQ 4

The safest general verdict pattern across liberty-equality-justice stems is that the ideals are:

A. such that liberty always trumps equality B. such that equality always trumps liberty C. never in conflict with one another D. complementary at the base and rivalrous only beyond a threshold, ordered by justice

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Equal basic liberties are themselves an equality; conflict appears only past a threshold, where justice adjudicates. Flat 'always' claims lose the degree marks.

MCQ 5

The foundational premise of equality as a political ideal is:

A. the equal moral worth of persons, whatever their birth or status B. that all people are identical in ability C. that all incomes must be exactly equal D. that relevant differences should never be recognised

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Equality begins from equal moral worth / equal consideration, not from a false claim of identical capacities or mandated identical incomes.

MCQ 6

'Formal / legal equality' refers to:

A. equal economic outcomes for all B. equal treatment before the law and equal application of rules C. proportional representation in the legislature D. equality of natural talents

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Formal/legal equality is equality before and under the law; it is necessary but, taken alone, compatible with deep social and economic disadvantage.

MCQ 7

Equality of opportunity differs from equality of outcome in that opportunity-equality:

- A. guarantees identical final results for everyone
- B. is simply another name for formal legal equality
- C. equalises starting conditions and access rather than final shares
- D. is rejected by every liberal thinker

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Opportunity equality targets fair access and starting conditions; outcome equality targets final distributions. Fair equality of opportunity is a central liberal-egalitarian demand.

MCQ 8

The reminder that 'equality is not sameness' means that:

- A. equality requires abolishing every human difference
- B. equality and identity are exact synonyms
- C. equal treatment always requires literally identical treatment
- D. treating people as equals can require differentiated treatment responsive to relevant differences

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Treating people AS equals (equal concern and respect) sometimes requires unequal treatment - e.g. accommodating disability or disadvantage - so equality is not mechanical sameness.

MCQ 9

Rousseau's distinction between natural and moral/political inequality holds that:

- A. the most oppressive inequalities are conventionally produced, not natural
- B. all inequality is rooted in biology
- C. natural inequality is the only real inequality
- D. inequality does not exist in civil society at all

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Natural inequality (strength, age, health) becomes politically toxic only when institutions - property, status - convert it into durable domination.

MCQ 10

For J.S. Mill, equality is compatible with:

- A. the suppression of individuality
- B. individuality and free self-development
- C. legally enforced identical lifestyles
- D. the permanent subjection of women

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Mill's egalitarianism prizes free self-development and expressly rejects the subjection of women; equality secures the conditions for individuality, not its suppression.

MCQ 11

Marx's claim that 'equal right is a right of inequality' is aimed at:

- A. the equality of women
- B. the political equality of votes
- C. abstract, formally equal exchange that ignores unequal needs and class position
- D. Rawls's difference principle

Correct answer: C

Explanation: A single common measure applied to unequally-placed people reproduces disadvantage; Marx exposes the class content beneath formally equal exchange.

MCQ 12

On a disciplined reading, the Marxian principle 'to each according to his need' is:

A. an immediate market wage rule B. identical to equality of opportunity C. a demand for equal incomes right now D. a principle for a higher stage of cooperation, not a present salary formula

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Reading the need-principle as a present pay rule invites the 'vague / weakens incentive' objection; Marx locates it at a transformed, higher stage of production.

MCQ 13

Amartya Sen's answer to 'equality of what?' foregrounds:

A. capabilities - the real freedom to achieve valued functionings B. equality of subjective welfare only C. equality of primary goods only D. strict equality of money income

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Sen shifts the metric from resources/welfare to capabilities: the effective freedom to be and do what one has reason to value.

MCQ 14

Sen's critique of resourcism (e.g. Rawlsian primary goods) is that:

A. resources are wholly irrelevant to justice B. equal resources yield unequal real freedom because people differ in conversion C. capabilities can never be compared D. income is the only measure that matters

Correct answer: B

Explanation: People convert resources into functionings at different rates (disability, metabolism, social role), so equal primary goods can still leave unequal real freedom.

MCQ 15

Dworkin's 'equality of resources' is distinctive for being:

A. indifferent to personal responsibility B. a direct equalisation of welfare C. ambition-sensitive but endowment-insensitive - holding people responsible for choices, not brute luck D. a rejection of all markets and prices

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Dworkin's scheme (hypothetical auction and insurance) lets outcomes track chosen ambitions while neutralising unchosen brute-luck disadvantages in endowment.

MCQ 16

The shared upshot of the 'equality of what?' debate is that:

A. equality is a single, self-evident quantity B. only money-income equality matters C. the metric of equality is ultimately irrelevant D. specifying the metric (welfare / resources / capability) is unavoidable and shapes the institutions required

Correct answer: D

Explanation: There is no metric-free equality: choosing welfare, resources or capability changes both the diagnosis of injustice and the remedies demanded.

MCQ 17

Berlin's NEGATIVE liberty is:

A. the absence of deliberate interference by others within one's area of action B. self-mastery achieved through rational autonomy C. participation in collective self-rule D. freedom understood as non-domination

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Negative liberty answers 'how many doors are open?' - the extent of the area within which one is left un-interfered with.

MCQ 18

Berlin warned that POSITIVE liberty can be perverted when:

A. it is defined merely as non-interference B. a 'higher self' is invoked to coerce people 'for their own good' C. it is applied only to economic life D. it is limited by Mill's harm principle

Correct answer: B

Explanation: The danger is the split-self move: identifying a 'real' self whose freedom justifies coercing the actual person - the pathway from self-mastery to authoritarian control.

MCQ 19

Mill's harm principle holds that power may be exercised over an individual against their will only to:

A. improve their moral character B. enforce the majority's morality C. prevent harm to others D. maximise their own happiness

Correct answer: C

Explanation: The sole legitimate ground for coercion is preventing harm to others; purely self-regarding conduct lies outside rightful interference.

MCQ 20

A common misreading of Mill's On Liberty treats it as:

A. a defence of free discussion B. a limit on paternalism C. a defence of individuality D. an endorsement of unlimited licence with no regard for others

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Mill defends liberty of self-regarding action and discussion, not licence: the harm principle itself sets the boundary against injury to others.

MCQ 21

For Locke, liberty is best described as:

A. freedom under known, settled law that protects natural rights - licence is not liberty B. freedom wherever the law happens to be silent C. obedience to the general will D. the positive power to flourish

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Locke ties liberty to life under settled, rights-protecting law and sharply distinguishes liberty from licence.

MCQ 22

Rousseau's phrase that a citizen may be 'forced to be free' is examiner-bait because it:

A. clearly endorses anarchism B. can be read as legitimate collective self-rule OR as a licence for coercion C. openly rejects the general will D. denies that any law can bind

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Both readings are textually available - co-authored law vs majoritarian coercion - which is exactly why it must be handled with a balanced verdict.

MCQ 23

T.H. Green's contribution to the concept of liberty is:

A. reducing liberty to bare non-interference B. equating liberty with security C. positive / enabling freedom - the power to do worthwhile things D. denying that education has any bearing on freedom

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Green's freedom is enabling: non-interference is hollow for someone disabled by ignorance or destitution, so institutions should widen worthwhile options.

MCQ 24

The best statement of the liberty-equality relation is that they:

A. are permanent, level-independent enemies B. are always exactly identical C. require equality to be sacrificed to liberty in every case D. reinforce at the level of basic liberties and conflict mainly beyond a threshold

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Equal basic liberties are themselves an equality; the clash is a matter of degree that appears only when demands rise above a threshold.

MCQ 25

Republican freedom as non-domination is the absence of:

A. another's capacity for arbitrary interference, whether exercised or not B. all law and government C. any inequality of wealth whatsoever D. positive self-mastery

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Domination is a standing capacity to interfere arbitrarily; one is unfree when subject to it even if the power is never actually used.

MCQ 26

The 'un-interfered-with slave' example shows that:

A. interference and domination are identical B. one can be dominated (and so unfree) even without any actual interference C. domination requires physical force D. non-interference always guarantees freedom

Correct answer: B

Explanation: A slave with an indulgent master suffers no interference yet must defer and self-censor - real unfreedom an interference-count cannot detect.

MCQ 27

On the republican view, non-arbitrary law is:

- A. always a pure subtraction from liberty
- B. wholly irrelevant to freedom
- C. freedom-constituting, because it strips others of arbitrary power
- D. identical to domination

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Where the negative view sees every law as a cost to liberty, republicanism sees non-arbitrary, contestable law as constitutive of freedom.

MCQ 28

The correct provenance discipline for the non-domination module is to:

- A. quote Pettit's page numbers freely
- B. treat Skinner as the normative theorist
- C. attribute the historical recovery to Pettit
- D. cite Pettit (1997) for theory and Skinner (1998) for history, by title and year, without quotation

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Pettit supplies the normative theory and Skinner the historical recovery; cite by title and year only, with no quoted text or page detail.

MCQ 29

Plato's concept of justice is:

- A. harmony - each part of soul and city performing its own proper function
- B. the equal distribution of income
- C. the will of the stronger
- D. the maximisation of aggregate utility

Correct answer: A

Explanation: For Plato justice is right-order: reason ruling the soul and each class doing its own work in the city, not external distribution.

MCQ 30

Aristotle's DISTRIBUTIVE justice requires:

- A. arithmetic equality for all regardless of merit
- B. proportional shares that track relevant merit
- C. the rectification of transactional wrongs
- D. the abolition of private property

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Distributive justice allocates goods in proportion to relevant desert or merit - proportional, not arithmetic, equality.

MCQ 31

Aristotle's CORRECTIVE justice is characterised by:

- A. proportional distribution by desert
- B. harmony of the parts of the soul
- C. arithmetic restoration of a balance disturbed by a wrong
- D. the maximisation of capability

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Corrective justice restores the prior balance between two parties after a transaction or wrong, treating them as arithmetically equal.

MCQ 32

The 'criteria problem' in the theory of justice is:

A. deciding whether justice exists at all B. proving that Plato was correct C. abolishing all distributive criteria D. identifying which criterion (need / desert / merit / contribution / equal share / compensation) governs which sphere

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Injustice often consists in exporting a criterion out of its proper sphere (e.g. wealth buying political power); the task is to match criterion to good.

MCQ 33

In Rawls's theory the lexically FIRST principle is:

A. equal basic liberties for all B. the difference principle C. fair equality of opportunity D. the maximisation of average utility

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Equal basic liberty is lexically prior and is never traded for economic gain; it is therefore false to say Rawls's first principle is equality.

MCQ 34

Nozick's entitlement theory of justice is:

A. a patterned principle of distribution B. a historical theory: justice depends on just acquisition, transfer and rectification C. a defence of the difference principle D. a capability metric

Correct answer: B

Explanation: For Nozick a distribution is just if it arose by just steps, whatever its shape; the Wilt Chamberlain case shows patterns require constant interference with free transfers.

MCQ 35

Sen's distinction between niti and nyaya emphasises:

A. rules to the exclusion of outcomes B. purely transcendental institutional design C. justice realised in actual lives, not merely correct institutions D. the abolition of public reasoning

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Niti is the correctness of rules/institutions; nyaya is justice as it is realised in people's lives - Sen prioritises comparative removal of manifest injustice.

MCQ 36

Ambedkar's political philosophy insists that political democracy is unstable without:

A. a minimal, night-watchman state B. the veil of ignorance C. the entitlement theory of holdings D. social democracy grounded in liberty, equality and fraternity

Correct answer: D

Explanation: For Ambedkar formal political equality is hollow while social hierarchy (caste) persists; fraternity and social democracy underwrite political democracy.

MCQ 37

A high-scoring 'compare Rawls and Nozick' answer should:

- A. fix shared axes and adjudicate, rather than write two separate biographies
- B. narrate each thinker's life story in turn
- C. avoid reaching any verdict
- D. consist mainly of long quotations from both

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Comparison marks reward shared axes (starting point, unit of concern, role of the state) run down for both thinkers, followed by a reasoned adjudication.

MCQ 38

Which is a genuine 'trap' the canonical file warns against?

- A. distinguishing negative from positive liberty
- B. saying Rawls's first principle is equality rather than liberty
- C. citing Ambedkar philosophically
- D. giving a graded, balanced verdict

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Rawls's first principle is equal LIBERTY; misstating it as equality is a classic error the traps section flags.

MCQ 39

The directive 'critically evaluate' primarily rewards:

- A. one-sided advocacy for a favoured thinker
- B. a bare list of definitions
- C. an objection-and-reply structure closing with a graded verdict
- D. the longest possible introduction

Correct answer: C

Explanation: 'Critically evaluate' scores the objection-reply layer and a verdict that concedes something to the losing side, not one-sided praise or demolition.

MCQ 40

The claim 'justice is not identical to law' means that:

- A. all laws are necessarily unjust
- B. justice is whatever the sovereign commands
- C. legality and legitimacy are the same thing
- D. a legally valid rule can still be unjust - legality is not sufficient for justice

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Legal validity and moral justice can diverge; conflating them collapses the critical standpoint from which laws are judged unjust.

Remedial MCQ 41

REMEDIAL (corrects 'Rawls makes equality his first principle'): the accurate statement is that:

- A. Rawls's first principle is equal LIBERTY, lexically prior to the difference principle
- B. Rawls has no priority rules among principles
- C. Rawls rejects basic liberties
- D. Rawls simply maximises aggregate welfare

Correct answer: A

Explanation: The equal-basic-liberties principle is lexically first; economic principles (fair opportunity, difference principle) are subordinate to it.

Remedial MCQ 42

REMEDIAL (corrects 'Berlin rejects positive liberty'): in fact Berlin:

A. equates the two liberties as one concept B. distinguishes (does not reject) positive liberty, warning only against its abuse C. denies that negative liberty exists D. defends positive liberty exclusively

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Berlin analyses both concepts; his target is the perversion of positive liberty via a coercive 'higher self', not positive liberty as such.

Remedial MCQ 43

REMEDIAL (corrects 'equity and equality are the same'): correctly stated:

A. equity means identical shares for everyone B. equality means need-adjusted shares C. equality applies a common measure, whereas equity differentiates by need D. neither concept has anything to do with distribution

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Equality = one measure for all; equity = differentiated response to unequal need. Treating unequally-placed people identically can be inequitable.

Remedial MCQ 44

REMEDIAL (corrects 'Nozick defends a patterned distribution'): in fact Nozick:

A. endorses the difference principle B. requires an end-state of equality C. is a welfare egalitarian D. is historical / entitlement-based and rejects fixed patterns (Wilt Chamberlain)

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Nozick's justice-in-holdings judges the PROCESS (acquisition, transfer, rectification), not the shape; maintaining a pattern would violate free transfer.

Remedial MCQ 45

REMEDIAL (corrects 'Mill's harm principle allows coercion for a person's own good'): correctly stated, the harm principle:

A. restricts coercion to preventing harm to OTHERS, not self-regarding conduct B. authorises censorship of unpopular opinion C. requires the suppression of individuality D. permits coercion to enforce the majority's tastes

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Self-regarding conduct is protected; only conduct that harms others is a legitimate ground for interference - the opposite of paternalism.

Remedial MCQ 46

REMEDIAL (corrects 'non-interference guarantees freedom'): the republican correction is that:

A. interference and domination are identical B. a dependent who is not currently interfered with may still be dominated and unfree C. law can never constitute freedom D. domination requires actual physical force

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Freedom is absence of DOMINATION (arbitrary power), not merely absence of interference; the un-interfered-with dependent is still unfree.

Remedial MCQ 47

REMEDIAL (corrects 'Sen's capability approach is mere welfare economics'): correctly stated, Sen's account:

A. equates capability with money income B. abandons freedom as a central value C. is political-philosophical - capabilities as freedom, refined through public reasoning D. rejects any comparison of social states

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Sen's capabilities are about real freedom and are shaped by public reasoning and comparative assessment - not a narrow welfarist metric.

Remedial MCQ 48

REMEDIAL (corrects 'justice as fairness means identical shares for all'): correctly stated, Rawls holds that:

A. all inequality whatsoever is banned B. the difference principle forbids every inequality C. fairness requires strictly equal outcomes D. inequalities are permitted if they meet fair equality of opportunity and benefit the least advantaged

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Justice as fairness tolerates inequalities that satisfy fair equality of opportunity and improve the position of the least advantaged - not equal outcomes.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Three original questions authored for this package (not PYQs), one each at 10, 15 and 20 marks, with full model solutions.

Original Mains 1

Original 10-marker - Social and Political Ideals - approx. 150 words.

Question: Distinguish formal equality from substantive equality. Can formal equality itself entrench substantive disadvantage? Answer in 150 words.

Model solution

Thesis. Formal equality (identical treatment under identical rules) and substantive equality (equal real standing and capability) can diverge, and formal equality applied to unequally-placed people can freeze existing disadvantage.

- **Formal equality.** Equality before the law and equal application of rules; necessary against arbitrary privilege.

- **Substantive equality.** Equal effective freedom to participate and flourish - Sen's capability register, not mere legal identity.

- **How formal equality entrenches disadvantage.** A single common measure ignores unequal starting points; "the same rule for all" can ratify an unequal race (Rousseau's converted inequality; Marx's "equal right is a right of inequality"). Formal equality is then a floor, not the whole of equality.

Verdict. Formal equality is indispensable but incomplete; substantive equality supplies what identical treatment cannot, so justice must decide when equal treatment requires differentiated response.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks - it fixes the two senses precisely, names the mechanism of entrenchment, and grades formal equality as necessary-but-partial rather than dismissing it.

Original Mains 2

Original 15-marker - Social and Political Ideals - approx. 250 words.

Question: Berlin distinguished two concepts of liberty. Is a third concept of liberty needed? Critically examine. Answer in 250 words.

Model solution

Thesis. Berlin's negative/positive pair is powerful but incomplete; the republican concept of freedom as NON-DOMINATION captures an unfreedom neither of Berlin's concepts sees, so a third concept is defensible - though it can be partially absorbed by a demanding negative liberty.

- **Berlin's pair.** Negative liberty = absence of interference; positive liberty = self-mastery. Berlin's warning: positive liberty invites a coercive "higher self".

- **The gap.** On a pure interference-count, a slave with an indulgent master is "free" because not currently interfered with. Intuitively he is unfree: he must defer, flatter and self-censor because the master CAN interfere arbitrarily. Neither non-interference (there is none) nor self-mastery (the point is external) explains this.

- **The third concept.** Freedom as non-domination = absence of another's standing CAPACITY for arbitrary interference. Interference is an act; domination is a status. Non-arbitrary, contestable law becomes freedom-constituting.

- **Objection and reply.** A Berlinian may say non-domination is just a high probability of future interference - reducible to negative liberty. Reply: probability can be LOW precisely where dependence is total, and domination also explains the dependent's own deference, which a bare interference-count cannot. Concede that the boundary of "arbitrary" remains contestable.

Verdict. A third concept earns its place by naming dependence as unfreedom; whether it is genuinely irreducible or a refined negative liberty is the live debate - the defensible answer is a qualified "yes".

MEMORY: Why this earns marks - it states Berlin accurately, uses the un-interfered-with dependent as argument, gives objection-reply, and returns a qualified verdict rather than a flat one.

Original Mains 3

Original 20-marker - Social and Political Ideals - approx. 250 words.

Question: 'Justice is the architectonic political ideal that orders liberty and equality.' Critically evaluate. Answer in 250 words.

Model solution

Thesis. The statement is largely defensible: because liberty and equality are each indeterminate about their own content, justice supplies the ordering criteria that fix their scope and priority - though "architectonic" must not be read as justice replacing the other two.

- **Why liberty is indeterminate.** "Liberty" does not say which liberties are basic or how to weigh one person's freedom against another's; negative, positive and republican conceptions pull apart. Rawls's lexical priority of equal basic liberties is a JUSTICE-supplied ranking.

- **Why equality is indeterminate.** "Equality of what?" - status, opportunity, resources, welfare, capability - yields different institutions. Without a criterion, equality collapses into mechanical levelling or empty formalism.

- **What justice supplies.** Desert, fairness, entitlement, need, capability, rectification and public reason - the criteria that say which inequalities are justified and which liberties are protected. Compare orderings: Nozick (liberty-first) protects self-ownership but lets background injustice hollow real freedom; crude equality-first flattens choice and desert; Rawlsian justice-as-ordering balances them by principle. Ambedkar

adds that political liberty and equality are unstable without fraternity and social democracy.

- **Objection and reply.** Objection: this inflates justice into a master-value

and demotes liberty/equality to mere inputs. Reply: justice is the FORM, not a rival substance - it orders the very ideals it presupposes; without them there is nothing to order.

Verdict. Justice is architectonic in the ordering sense: liberty and equality are the substance, justice the discipline - each incomplete without the others.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks - it proves the thesis by demonstrating the indeterminacy of both ideals, compares three ordering positions, meets the master-value objection, and lands a precise architectonic verdict.